Attachment Styles in Relationships

Draws on attachment theory (Bowlby, Ainsworth) and adult attachment research

1 WHAT IS IT?

Attachment describes the emotional bond we form with the people we rely on most. From early caregivers to adult partners, we develop expectations about whether others will be there for us and whether we're worthy of care. Those expectations shape how we seek closeness and respond to distance.

2 HOW DOES IT WORK?



Attachment is best understood as two dimensions rather than four fixed types. Labels are shorthand for regions on a continuum. Original illustration.

3 WHY DOES IT HAPPEN?

Attachment theory began with John Bowlby and Mary Ainsworth's work on how children seek safety from caregivers. Researchers later found similar patterns in adult relationships, where a partner can be a safe haven in distress and a secure base for exploring life.

If closeness was reliable, it makes sense to expect it. If care was unpredictable or unavailable, staying on alert (anxiety) or relying only on yourself (avoidance) were smart adaptations. They made sense then; they may just cost more now. In couples, one partner pursuing and the other withdrawing can feed each other.

Good to know. Attachment patterns are not diagnoses, and no style is "bad." Your pattern can differ across relationships and change over time. Security can grow through safe relationships and therapy, often called earned security.

4 WHAT CAN HELP?

Notice your move under stress

When you feel distant from someone you love, do you move toward, pull away, or both? Noticing is the first step toward choosing.

Name the need underneath

Behind protest or withdrawal is usually a question: "Are you there for me? Do I matter to you?" Saying the softer need aloud invites a softer response.

Collect new experiences

Security grows through repeated experiences of being responded to. Consistent relationships, including a therapeutic one, can gradually update old expectations.

5 REFLECTION QUESTION

What did you learn early on about whether it was safe to need other people?

6 KEY TAKEAWAY

Your attachment pattern is a strategy you learned to stay safe, and what was learned can grow.

7 REFERENCES

1. Bartholomew, K., & Horowitz, L. M. (1991). Attachment styles among young adults: A test of a four-category model. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 61*(2), 226–244.
2. Bowlby, J. (1982). *Attachment and loss: Vol. 1. Attachment* (2nd ed.). Basic Books. (Original work published 1969)
3. Fraley, R. C. (2019). Attachment in adulthood: Recent developments, emerging debates, and future directions. *Annual Review of Psychology, 70*, 401–422.
4. Hazan, C., & Shaver, P. (1987). Romantic love conceptualized as an attachment process. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 52*(3), 511–524.
5. Mikulincer, M., & Shaver, P. R. (2016). *Attachment in adulthood: Structure, dynamics, and change* (2nd ed.). Guilford Press.

These resources are for education and self-reflection and are not a substitute for individualized mental health care.